

Why Conspiracy Theory Communities Endure

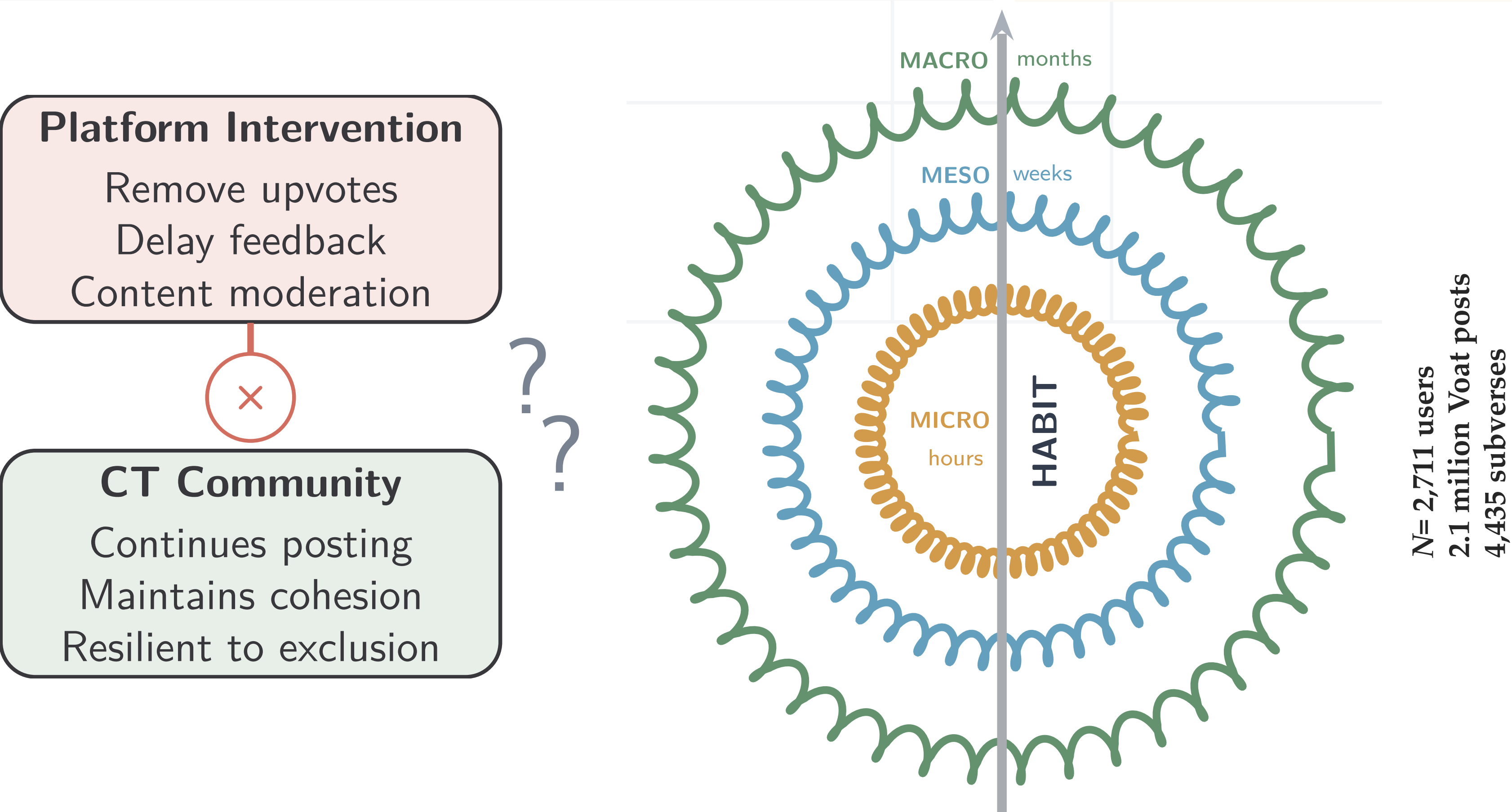
The Interplay of Feedback, Habits and Community Context

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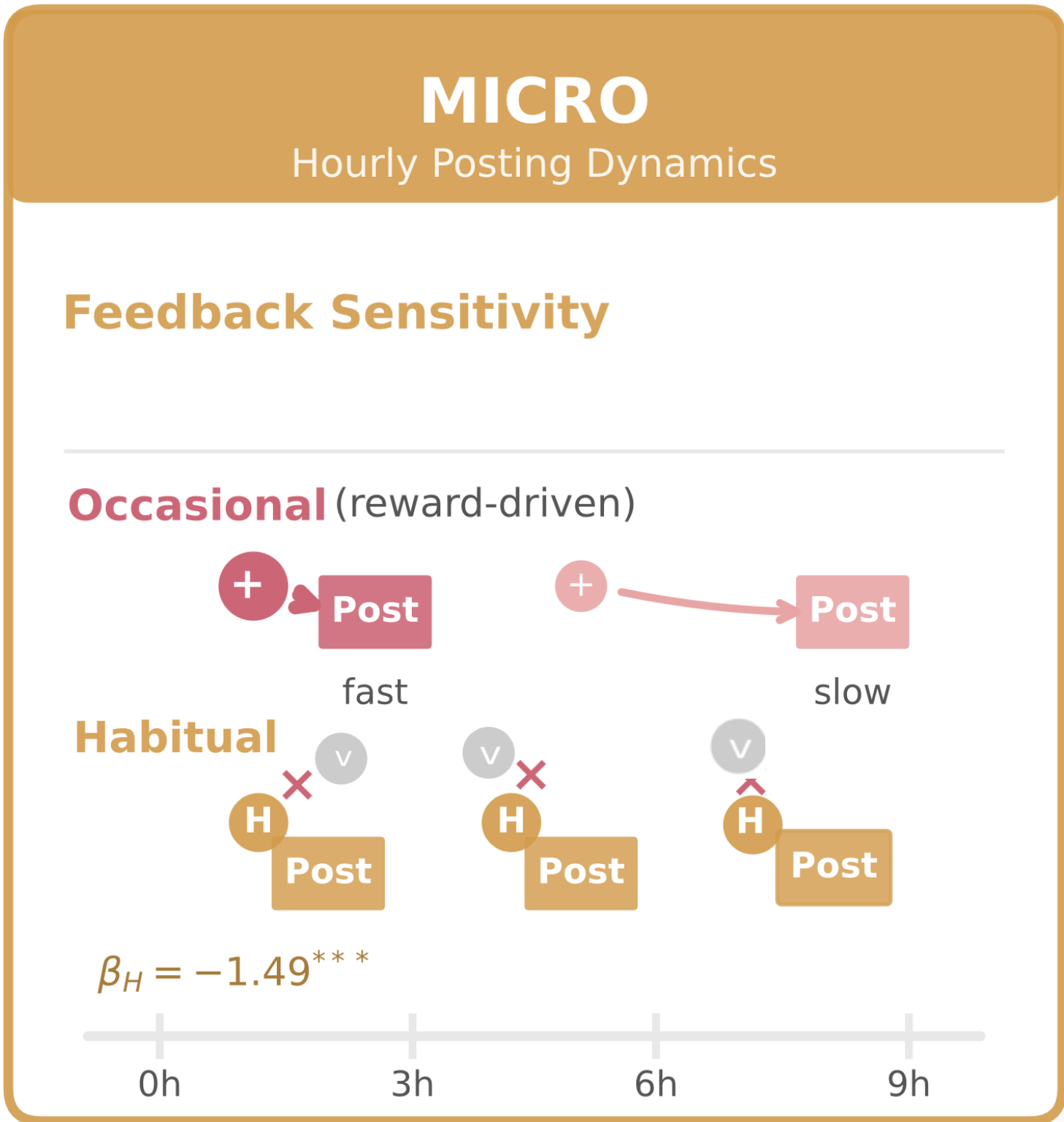
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The gap: Prior work examines *single timescales* — content, motivation, or network structure — but misses the **temporal architecture** of engagement.

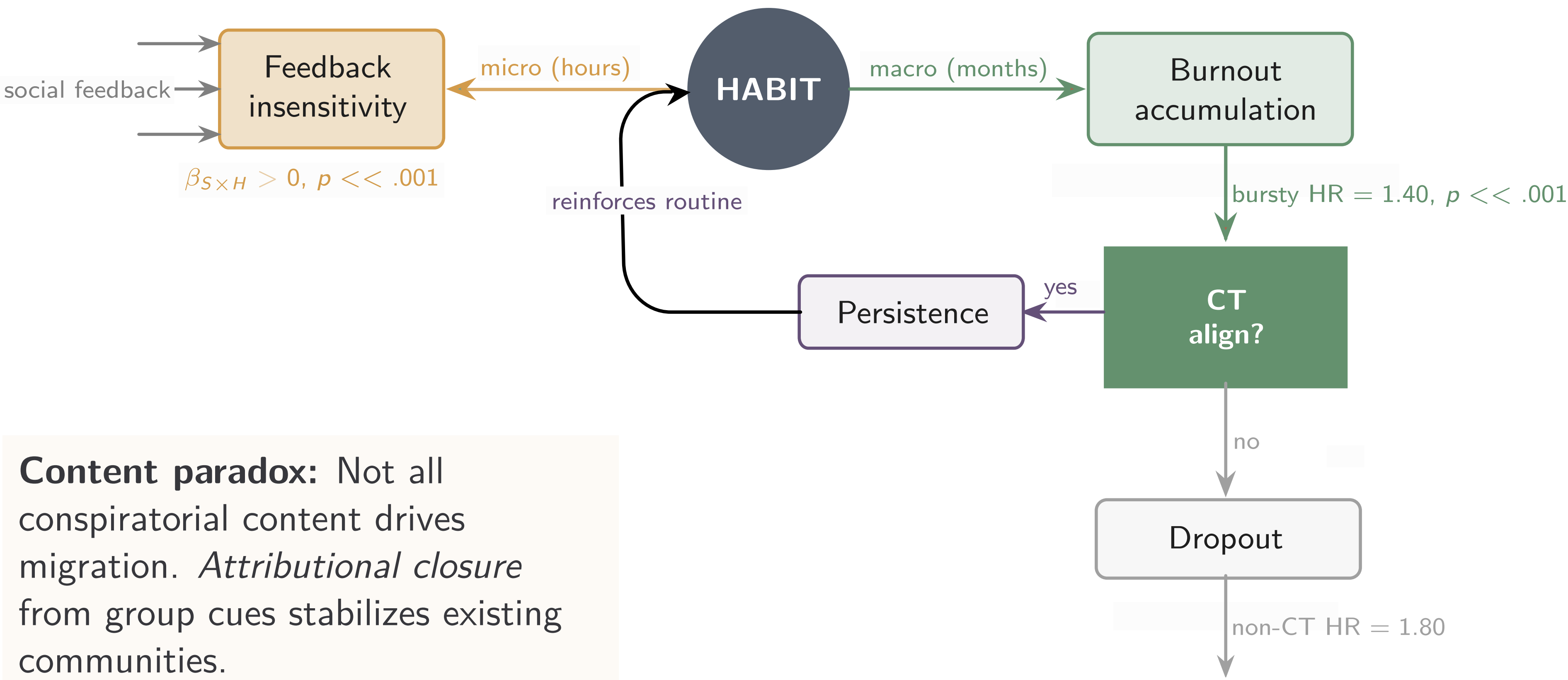
Habit as mechanism: Connects reinforcement learning (short-term) with social identity theory (long-term) through a measurable behavioral construct.



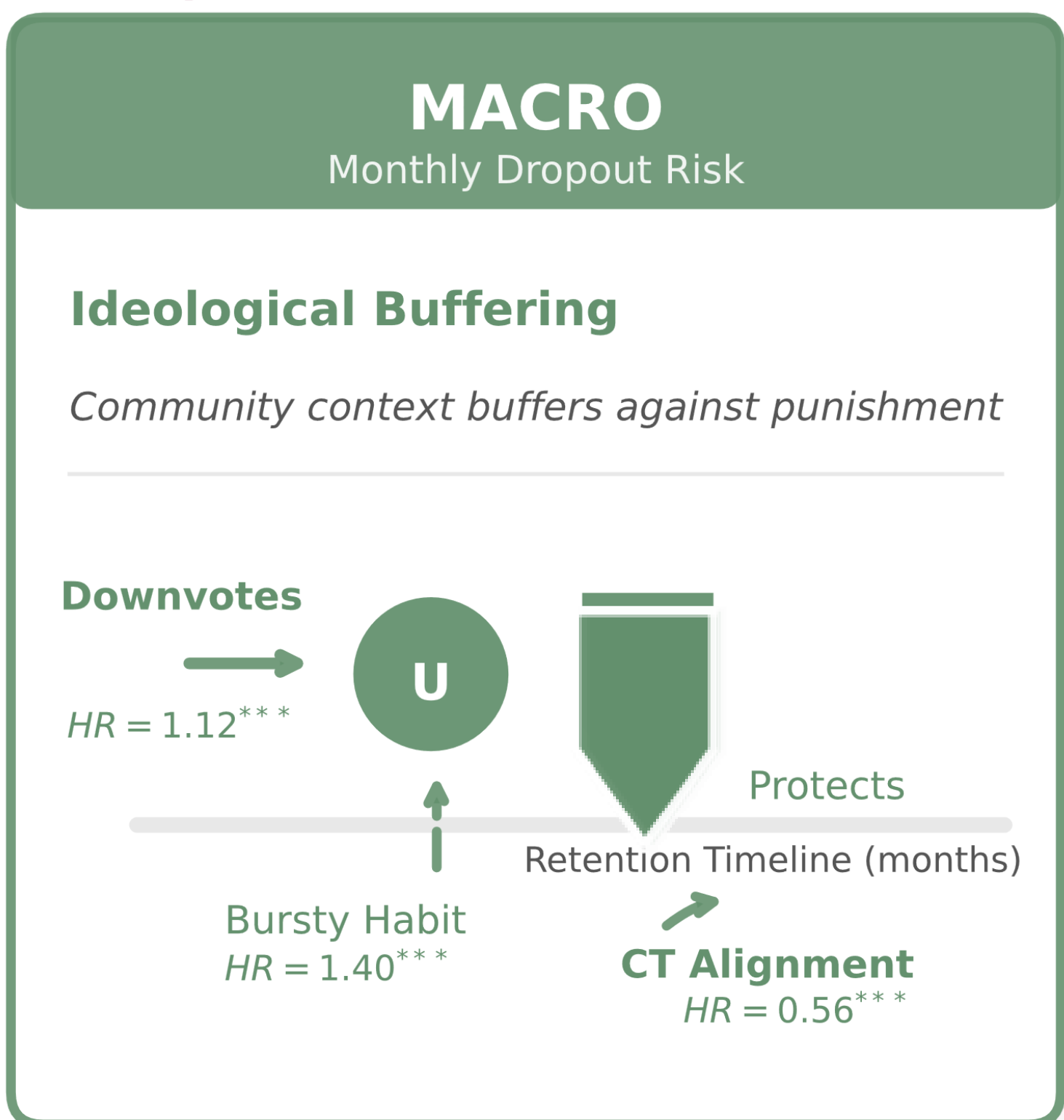
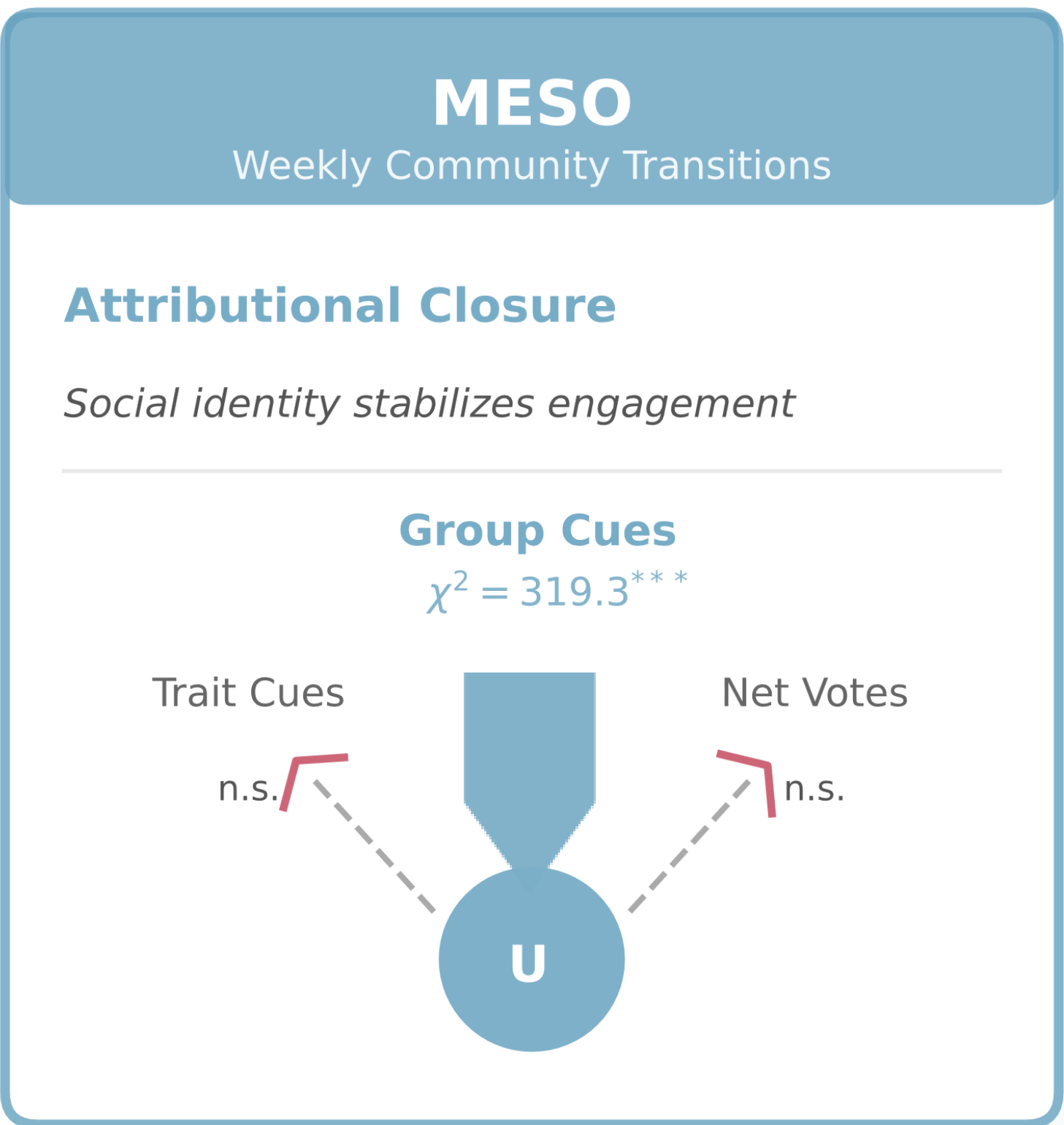
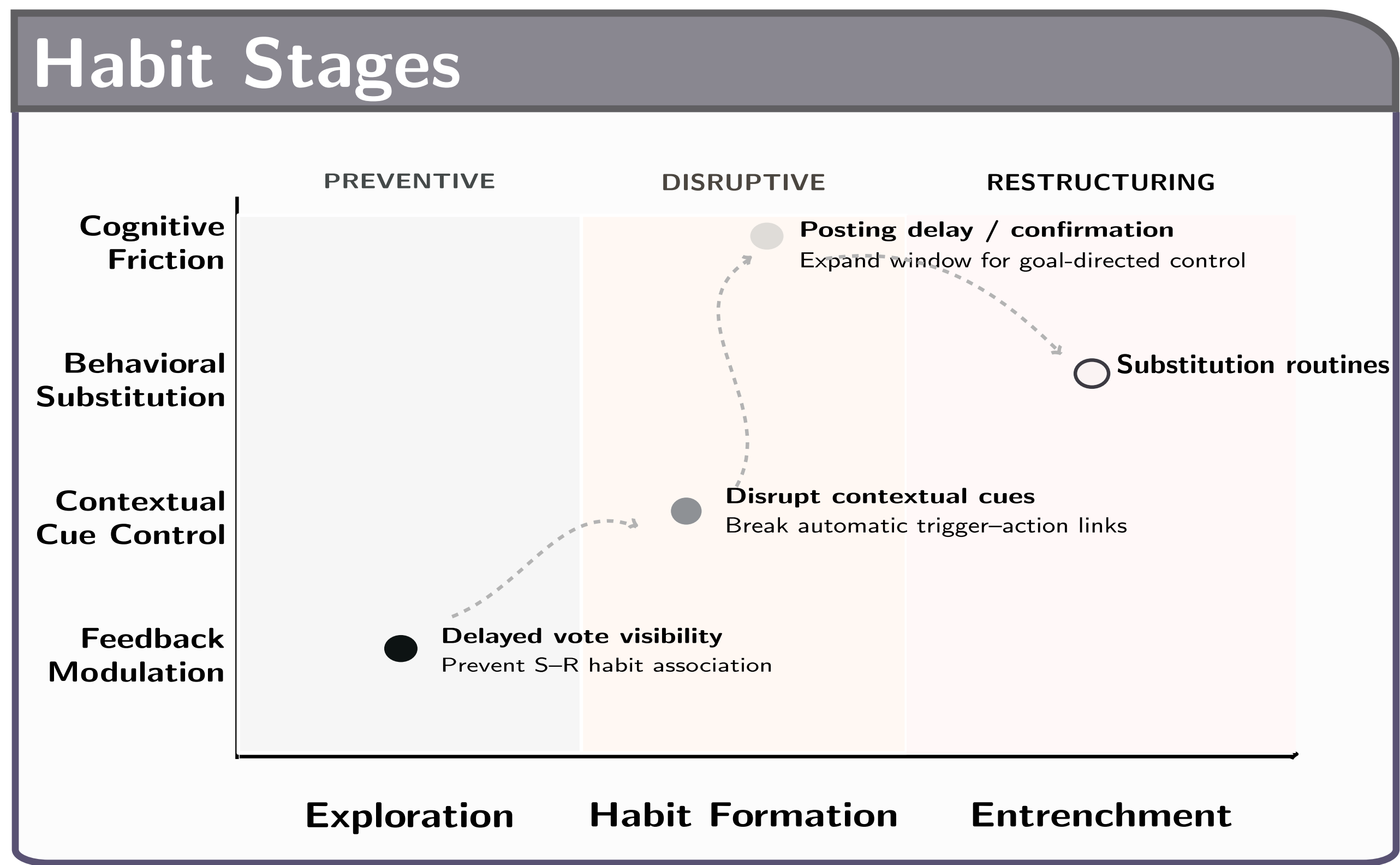
Conditional resilience: Community persistence is not about reward maximization but about **ideological buffering** against punishment.



The Conditional Habit Loop



Content paradox: Not all conspiratorial content drives migration. *Attributional closure* from group cues stabilizes existing communities.



Pipeline



1. Behavioral Embedding

User-subverse matrix $\rightarrow$ Word2Vec $\rightarrow$ PCA. Continuous ideological scores validated against human labels (AUC 0.80).

2. Evolutionary Features

Five theory-driven narrative features (Secrecy, Pattern, Threat, Actor, Action) via fine-tuned BERT. Grounded in cognitive evolution.

3. Matched Multiscale Stats

Micro: LMMs. Meso: GAMMs with penalized smooths. Macro: Cox PH with time-varying covariates & frailty.

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